OTT

Lose Control

Vikramaditya Motwane examines the perils of digital dependence in his screenlife thriller *Ctrl*

Vikramaditya Motwane has a thing for loners. In *Trapped*, he captured the desperation of a man stuck in a highrise apartment. *Bhavesh Joshi Superhero* was about a vigilante who cuts himself off by hiding at an abandoned site. In his latest, *Ctrl* [streaming on Netflix], an influencer (Ananya Panday) unknowingly cedes control of her life to an app and has an isolated existence. Is *Ctrl* then the conclusion of a trilogy? "If anything, it'd be start of a 'Ctrl Alt Del' trilogy," he says with a laugh. "We have a story for 'Alt'. We haven't come to 'Del' as yet."

Ctrl is what one would call a screenlife thriller, a genre wherein most of the narrative unfolds on laptop and mobile screens and using devices like CCTV cameras. "It is so voyeuristic, but we don't realise how familiar we are with the format—texting, watching YouTube videos, Google searches," says Motwane of the genre which has seen films like Hollywood's *Searching* and Malayalam drama *CU Soon*.

Given how much time its Gen Z protagonist spends on her devices, *Ctrl* is laden with commentary. It is likely to make viewers think twice the next time they tick yes while agreeing to terms and agreements without reading them and dwell on artificial intelligence. Says Motwane, "I delete Instagram every second day, but I also re-download it. The tragedy of our lives is that we will stay online."

Also the film's co-writer, he wanted *Ctrl* to be less a statement against the influencer culture and more an examination of the constant need for gratification in the form of likes. "I read somewhere that we will see social media in the next 20 years the way we look at smoking. We have done so much damage by having people want their dopamine hit through validation," he says. Motwane roped in stand-up comic, actress and writer Sumukhi Suresh to do the dialogue. The idea, he said, was to make it "authentic" and not a "snide-y look from the ivory tower on who influencers are".

Like a lot of the screenlife thrillers, *Ctrl* too was made on the editing table. Shot in 16 days mostly on an iPhone, Motwane spent 16 months in post-production. "We geeked out on shooting it. It was a massive learning curve," he says. It helped that the screenlife genre allows much scope for experimentation by narrating a scene through audio, video or even text. It's also why Motwane feels the film lends itself well to having an OTT release. "It is OK to watch on the phone too," he says.



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Ctrl is the fourth title under Motwane's banner Andolan Films, all of which have been streaming releases. That's not to say he's averse to the big screen—after all, he received much adulation for his debut, *Udaan*, which was followed by *Lootera*. His next though will be a web series, *Black Warrant*. There's also a documentary, *Indi(r)a's Emergency*, which is looking for distribution. "I made it as a *masala* documentary," says Motwane. "It's an accessible and interesting snapshot of our times with a phenomenal protagonist and she is real." ■

–Suhani Singh



» **VOYEUR ACT**
Ananya Panday and Vihaan Samat in *Ctrl*